PART II · TIME · 5

# Compound and irregular time

Compound time skips: each dotted beat splits into **three**. Irregular time keeps you guessing, with **five or seven** counts in uneven groups. (9/4, 12/4 and /16 signatures are rare.)

THE SECRET

**Dotted beats split in three: 6/8 is two big beats.**

## 3/4 or 6/8?




3/4: six quavers in three twos




6/8: six quavers in two threes

SIMPLE OR COMPOUND?
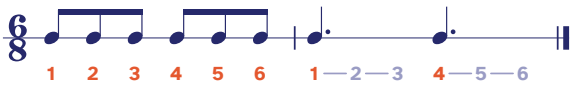
In **simple time** each beat divides into **two**. In **compound time** each beat is a dotted note and divides into **three**.

**Quick test:** a top number of 6, 9 or 12 means compound. Divide it by 3 to find the beats: 6/8 has 2, 9/8 has 3, 12/8 has 4.

## Compound time

| TIME SIGNATURE | EACH BAR HOLDS | FIRST MET |
|---|---|---|
| 6/8 | 2 dotted crotchets | Level 1 |
| 9/8 | 3 dotted crotchets | Level 3 |
| 12/8 | 4 dotted crotchets | Level 3 |
| 6/4 | 2 dotted minims | Level 4 |

## Counting 6/8




Slowly, count all six quavers. At speed, feel two beats, on 1 and 4: “1 & a, 2 & a”.

## Irregular time

UNEVEN GROUPS IN 4/4

Many dances keep 4/4 but group the eight quavers 3 + 3 + 2: “1 2 3, 1 2 3, 1 2”.



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| TIME SIGNATURE | EACH BAR HOLDS | FIRST MET |
|---|---|---|
| 5/4 | 5 crotchets: 3 + 2 or 2 + 3 | Level 5 |
| 7/4 | 7 crotchets: 4 + 3 or 3 + 4 | *Extra* |
| 5/8 | 5 quavers: 3 + 2 or 2 + 3 | *Extra* |
| 7/8 | 7 quavers: 2 + 2 + 3 or 3 + 2 + 2 | *Extra* |

EXAMPLE 1

**Count 6/8 in two**

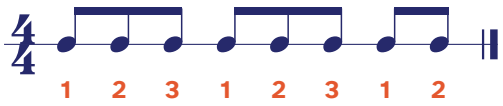



1. **Slowly, count all six:** 1 2 3 4 5 6.
2. **Lean on 1 and 4**, the red notes.
3. **Faster, count only those:** two beats, each a dotted crotchet.

6/8 has **two beats** in a bar, each split into three.

EXAMPLE 2

**Hear 3 + 3 + 2 inside 4/4**
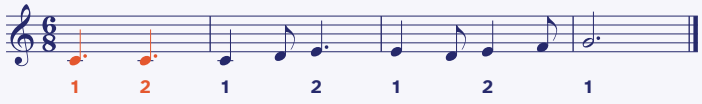



1. **Count eight quavers** in a bar of 4/4.
2. **Group them** 3 + 3 + 2, accenting 1, 4 and 7.
3. **Keep the beat** in your foot: it stays in four.

The bar is still **4/4**; only the accents are uneven.

YOU KNOW THIS

**Row, Row, Row Your Boat**




Two big beats in every bar, each a **dotted crotchet**: “Row, row”. Inside each beat, “gent-ly” splits it into three. That is 6/8.

**Try it.** Sway twice per bar while you sing it.

THINK OF IT Like a skipping rope: two big swings, each with three little steps inside.

SEE ALSO

Time signatures p. 41 · Rhythm: groups and upbeats p. 45

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Levels 1–4 · Compound time · Online: Rhythm clock